corporate executives, hoping to boost India's stature and also to strengthen its economy and military. We have to wait and see how far he will succeed in this endeavour.

Nehru's immediate successor as prime minister, Lal Bahadur Shastri, remained in office rather briefly from 1964 to 1966. As a former colleague of Nehru, Shastri did not alter Nehru's policies during his short stint. India's second war with Pakistan, in 1965, was the key event during Shastri's tenure. By most accounts, Shastri handled the war and India's foreign and defence policies extremely well though he had no foreign policy experience before becoming prime minister. Until then, domestic politics had been his forte.

India's foreign policy evolved significantly when Nehru's daughter, Indira Gandhi became prime minister in 1966, two years after her father's death. She served in that job from 1966 to 1977 and then again from 1980 until her assassination in 1984. Indira had grown up amidst politics as the granddaughter of Motilal Nehru (1861–1931) and the daughter of Jawaharlal Nehru, both important figures in India's independence struggle. After her father became prime minister, Indira was, in Dixit's words, 'a personal witness to and participant in major political developments both domestically and in terms of India's external relations'. [73] She knew almost every leader of not just the Congress party but of the national movement since her childhood.

Indira served as her widower father's official hostess and companion during his years in power. She had interacted with many of the world's leaders and policymakers well before taking office as prime minister. But Nehru, reluctant to be seen as practising dynastic politics, avoided anointing Indira as his successor. It was only in 1959, twelve years after he took over as premier and after she had earned her spurs, that Indira was chosen president of the Congress party. Nehru also nominated her on behalf of